

# Silver lining in Hangzhou

A **runner-up finish** at the recent Asia Cup gives Harendra Singh and his players a boost ahead of the all-important World Cup qualifiers in early 2026.

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**T**he Indian women's hockey team will have to wait a few more months to know if it will join the men in Belgium and the Netherlands at next year's World Cup. A runner-up finish at the recent Asia Cup, behind host and eventual champion China, meant the Indians left disappointed but not without a measure of satisfaction.

Before the team left for Hangzhou, the venue of its Asian Games heartbreak two years ago, expectations were muted. A 4-1

**Traditional rivals:** India and China have now clashed in three Asia Cup finals, with the Indians tasting glory in their 2017 meeting. X/ @THEHOCKEYINDIA

series loss to Australia, preceded by an eight-match rout in Europe during the Pro League, had raised questions about both players and style. Unlike their male counterparts, the women never looked threatening enough. Against that backdrop, a silver medal was no small achievement.

**India's campaign itself was a mixed bag. The absence of key players hurt, but it also created opportunities for youngsters.** Injuries sidelined veteran goalkeeper Savita Punia and Sushila Chanu, yet Bichu Devi, long Savita's understudy, stepped up with confidence despite a few errors. Udit Duhan returned to shore up the defence and midfield. But the biggest blow came when Deepika, India's young drag-flicker and top-scoring hope, was forced out after slipping and hurting her hamstring and groin during the last

training session before the team's departure. Her absence was felt in the team's desperate search for goals.

**In attack, Navneet Kaur led the line and was ably supported by 22-year-old Mumtaz Khan.** The resurgence of Sangita Kumari was another bright spot. Once the star of the 2022 Commonwealth Games and Asian Champions Trophy, the 23-year-old had struggled over the past year. In Hangzhou, however, she rediscovered her pace and sharpness. She scored just twice but was instrumental in creating chances with her assists and pace upfront.

India's group-stage journey reflected its broader inconsistency. Crushing wins over minnows Thailand (11-0) and Singapore (12-0) were offset by a 2-2 draw against Japan — a pattern of dominance

